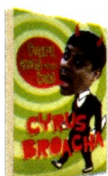


Death of LAUGHTER

Further proof of the fact that Indian humour writing is no longer funny

By Dilip Bobb



**KARL, AA
AUR KAL**

by CYRUS BROACHA
Random House India
Price: Rs 195
Pages: 230



**DORK: THE
INCREDIBLE
ADVENTURES OF
ROBIN 'EINSTEIN'
VARGHESE**

by SIDIN VADUKUT
Penguin
Price: Rs 199
Pages: 237

It's funny how difficult it is to find good humour writing in India. Not everyone can be a P.G. Wodehouse or an Art Buchwald but it's quite depressing to see how much drivel gets passed off as humour. On television, where laugh riots are all the rage, we have canned laughter and adult anchors rolling around on the floor even before a gag is complete. Also, consider this: everyone's favourite judge at such shows is veteran BJP politician and former opening batsman Navjot Singh Sidhu. Check out your nearest bookstore, the joke books on display are by historian/author Khushwant Singh, a man who likes to portray himself as a serious social commentator. Yet, humour is the new serious and stand-up comics are the new stars, replacing Bollywood hotties as award night compères and celebrity party hosts. And now, somewhat inevitably, as authors. Cyrus

Broacha is arguably India's best-known funny man courtesy radio, TV, newspaper columns and live show host. Someone had to give serious thought to extending that to a book and here it is with an awfully hackneyed title and somewhat dubious literary merit.

The problem is that Broacha is a hit because of his facial expressions, his physique, his personality, his spontaneity and his delivery style. Much of that is lost in translation into book form. Humour in writing takes many forms: satire, parody, irony, lampoon and just plain nonsense. Broacha's wit is a mix of

lampoon and plain nonsense, a case of *Mad* magazine meets the Marx Brothers. There are phrases and situations which remind one of his TV avatar but that is not a recommendation. Broacha's humour is not to everyone's taste and merely being self-deprecating is no substitute for intelligent wit. The story itself has lots of possibilities for drollness, Bollywood, Mumbai, television, even politics, but the Broacha treatment that resonates at some level when it's live, fails to find a literary foothold. At a juvenile level, it works. At a literary level, it's the equivalent of slapstick. The book is autobiographical in nature and revolves around a character called Karl (hence the title) but the humour is largely tacky, crass and very outdated. Spike Milligan, Peter Sellers and John Cleese did this on the Goon Show 30 years ago, around the same time *Mad* magazine was hitting its peak. Cyrus live is eminently watchable, albeit in small doses. As an author, he's seriously avoidable.

So too is Sidin Vadukut, but for different reasons. Why the publishers decided to slot *Dork* in the humour category is a mystery. It's a book that is B-school themed, Chetan Bhagat territory, and follows the fictional (largely autobiographical) career of the hero. The humour is strictly to do with a lot of cuss words, F...s and B.....s and similar abuses which are no substitute for wit. The book charts the protagonist's career in a management consulting firm and is largely about his co-workers, competition, back-stabbing, deadlines, office romances and projects, in essence, basic corporate life. Why all this should constitute humour is highly questionable since it's really impossible to find anything that is remotely funny. Which is a pity since there are situations in the narrative which offer fertile ground for wit and satire. Instead, we get what is basically a straight story about corporate life which, in today's age, is anything but amusing, much like *Dork*.

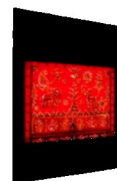
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